
Iruppu waterfalls in Madikeri, Karnataka

COORG

Known for its waterfalls and coffee plantations, Coorg is also home to the beautiful Madikeri Fort and the exquisite Namdroling Golden Temple at Bylakuppe. Recently, however, visitors have been seen forsaking these somewhat typical attractions for the adrenaline rush of outdoor adventure. If, like them, you want to sample Coorg's biodiversity, trek through its forested Brahmagiri range or climb Thadiyendamol, the region's tallest peak. There's rock climbing and windsurfing you can do at the Hyrige reservoir, while kayaking and canoeing are options on the Kabbe river. Also, if you want a bird's eye-view of the perennially lush Coorg, sign up for microlight flying at Ponnampet. It's worth the hype.

BHEEMESHWARI

Home to a wonderful, tucked away wildlife sanctuary, Bheemeshwari offers Bangaloreans a bit of everything—angling, kayaking, trekking, camping and safaris. Only 103 km away from the city, Bheemeshwari is situated on the banks of the Cauvery, and the abundance of fish here has led to several fishing camps come up in and around the town. Angling enthusiasts often come here looking to catch the Mahseer, one of the finest game fish in the world. Lovers of wildlife, on the other hand, come here to see the sanctuary's crocodiles and leopards.

TOP 5 PILGRIMAGE DESTINATIONS NEAR CHENNAI

MADURAI

One of the oldest cities in India, Madurai earns mention even in ancient Greek and Mughal texts. The Meenakshi Amman Temple is inarguably Madurai's heart. Dedicated to Meenakshi, an incarnation of Parvati, the enormous temple, with its high *gopurams* (towers), is one of the finest examples of Dravidian architecture. The Koodal Alagar Temple, on the other hand, shows Vishnu sitting, standing and lying down, while Thiruparankundram is a must-see on the bucket list of Lord Murugan devotees.

KUMBAKONAM

You're likely to find a temple around Kumbakonam's every bend, but there are some you absolutely must visit. Built by the Cholas, the Adi Kumbeshwara (known for its floral motifs) and Nageswaran (famous for its chariot-shaped sanctum) temples are dedicated to Shiva. The Chakrapani Temple has an eight-armed idol of Vishnu, and the Sarangapani Temple has a 15-tiered *gopuram* that is 175 ft high.

THANJAVUR

Thanjavur (Tanjore) is an essential stop. It is here that Raja Raja Chola I built the Brihadeeswarar Temple. The temple's inscriptions, frescoes and sculptures all narrate Shaivite lore with a beautiful, unprecedented elegance. Luckily, the carefully carved Gangaikonda Temple is only a short drive away.

KANYAKUMARI

Kanyakumari, India's southernmost town, is also the point where the Arabian Sea, Bay of Bengal and the Indian Ocean meet. Called 'Triveni Sangam', this point of confluence is considered sacred by many. Close by is the Kumari Amman Temple. In 1892, Swami Vivekananda visited Kanyakumari, and on the large offshore rock on which he meditated, there stands the magnificent Vivekananda Rock Memorial.


Vivekananda Rock Memorial, Kanyakumari

TIRUPATI

Devotees believe Vishnu came to Tirupati, following his beloved Lakshmi, who had left Vaikuntha in a huff. For the thousands who flock to the city's Sri Venkateswara Temple, Vishnu has never left this earthly adobe. Situated in the hilly suburb of Tirumala, the temple is said to be the richest in the world.